Stephen Hatcher – 'Rapture'

Stephen Hatcher shares one of his 'half-moon' forms with us, which fuses bigleaf maple and paua shell

PHOTOGRAPHS BY STEPHEN HATCHER

'Rapture', bigleaf maple, zircote, wood fibre veneer, paua shell, epoxy and lacquer, 140 x 255 x 90mm

Since 2005, I have made a great many 'half-moon' forms, both open and closed. These have proven popular with collectors and most recently, Denali National Park in Alaska, USA where I was an artist-in-residence in 2013. This form started as an experimental piece that would combine several new techniques. The name 'Rapture' came about at a gathering of artist friends who tossed out suggestions based on the inlay design. Some names were quite hysterical but this one stuck. 'Rapture' merges several disparate techniques and materials into a unique woodturning.

To start this project, bigleaf maple (*Acer macrophyllum*) was turned and cut in half so it looked like two half shells. The front half paua shell design was cut into the wood using a scrollsaw, the area backed with tape, then set with paua shell and clear epoxy. The inlay was finished prior to assembling the halves. When assembling, ebony veneer layers and thin-cut zircote were added to create the basic 'half-moon' form. Before assembly, temperature cycling of prototype wood joints was necessary to insure the proper adhesives and finish were selected given the varied materials. The interior joint was also inlaid with crushed paua shell and black guitar purfling – a process that was quite challenging due to the difficulty in sanding the area. The rim was added using zircote and black wood-fibre veneer where these materials were precut on a scrollsaw then glued to the half-moon body. Rotary carvers and sanders were used to blend these sections together. Four feet were carved and blended as well using these same carvers and sanders. The dramatic wood figure was further 'popped' using colourfast dyes. The piece is finished with 20 coats of hand-rubbed nitrocellulose lacquer.

A 'Collaboration of Materials' is a good description of this piece. The various elements that went into the artwork are very different and not very forgiving. The basic maple bowl turning was simple as was reassembling it into an elliptical vessel form. Then great care was required in the cutting and fitting of the different woods, veneers, and inlays. Like the insights required to make this piece, the paua inlay is semi-transparent, thereby allowing some light to pass out through the inlay and highlight the design when the piece is lit from above.

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